



People have invented hundreds of “number alphabets” throughout history, and a few of the important ones are shown here. They’re very different, but they do have some interesting things in common. Most began with a tally of simple marks, like lines or dots. And most had a change of style at 10 – the number for two full hands.

10	20	30	40	50	60	70	80	90	100
十	二十	三十	四十	五十	六十	七十	八十	九十	百
𐤁	𐤂	𐤃	𐤄	𐤅	𐤆	𐤇	𐤈	𐤉	𐤊
י	כ	ל	מ	נ	ס	ע	פ	צ	ק
I	K	Λ	M	N	E	O	Π	♀	P
X	XX	XXX	XL	L	LX	LXX	LXXX	XC	C
١٠	٢٠	٣٠	٤٠	٥٠	٦٠	٧٠	٨٠	٩٠	١٠٠